

Lesson 07

Case Study: It Project Brief



Warm-Up

Discussion:

- Have you ever needed to explain something technical to someone who was not an expert?
- What was difficult about it?
- Do you know any IT words that confuse you or your colleagues?



Role-Play

Scenario: Anna, the marketing manager, attends a meeting with David, the IT manager. David explains a new website security update:

Anna: Hi David, I heard we're making some security updates to the website. Can you tell me what's changing?

David: Absolutely. **In simple terms**, we're making the website safer for everyone who visits.

Anna: That sounds important. What exactly are you doing?

David: We're installing a digital "lock" called an SSL certificate. **To put it another way**, this means any information people enter on our website will be private and protected from hackers.

Anna: Oh, I see! And what about the other updates you mentioned?

David: Good question. We're also adding "two-factor authentication." **In layman's terms**, it's like needing two keys to open a door. This makes it much harder for anyone to break into our site without permission.

Anna: That makes sense. Will any of this affect my work on the website?

David: Not really. The updates will run in the background. But you might notice a small padlock icon in the web address bar, that shows the site is secure. If you have any trouble logging in, just let us know. **Does that make sense?**

Anna: Yes, thank you for explaining! That was really clear.

Role-play analysis:

1. Which phrases did David use to help explain technical ideas simply to Anna?
2. How did David check if Anna understood his explanations?
3. How did David turn technical terms (like “SSL certificate” or “two-factor authentication”) into clear, everyday language?
4. What could happen if David did not take time to explain these updates clearly?
5. Do you think it is always necessary to avoid all technical terms when speaking to non-technical people? Why or why not?



Vocabulary: Explaining Technical Terms

Language Functions	Useful Phrases
1. Avoid Jargon or Explain it	• “This is called ...” • “It means...” • “... is a technical term for...”
2. Use Short, Clear Sentences	• “To put it simply, ...” / “To put it another way, ...” • “In simple terms, ...” / “In layman’s terms, ...” • “What I mean is...”
3. Give Examples from Everyday Life	• “For example, ...” • “It’s like when you...” • “Imagine you have...”
4. Check Understanding	• “Does that make sense?” • “Is that clear?” • “Would you like me to explain more?”



Practice

1. Matching: Find Synonyms

Match each technical term to its synonym (words that have similar meanings):

Technical Terms

1. real time
2. encryption
3. migrate
4. database
5. synchronize
6. regression testing
7. security protocols
8. cloud-based infrastructure

Synonyms

- a. move / transfer
- b. match / update together
- c. checking again / retesting
- d. code / protection
- e. safety rules / security measures
- f. live / instantly
- g. data storage / information file
- h. online system / internet service

2. Role-play: Clarify Project Briefs

Work in pairs and choose a role for your activity. Switch roles after each turn.

Context: A non-technical colleague is asking an IT Specialist about a confusing IT project update that includes technical terms.

Role A: IT Specialist	Role B: Non-Technical Colleague
- Clarify project briefs using simple language or providing examples. - Check understanding after clarifications if necessary.	- Listen and check understanding. - Ask additional questions if necessary ("Can you give an example?", "Is that like ...?")

Example:

Original Brief: *“We need to optimize the user interface by enhancing the responsiveness and ensuring cross-platform compatibility before deployment.”*

B: *Can you please help me explaining our brief today?*

A: **To put it simply**, we want to make the app faster and easier to use before we make it available.

B: *Oh, I see. But what does “cross-platform compatibility” mean?*

A: **It means** you can use the app on different devices. **Would you like me to explain more?**

Project Briefs:

1. *“Our team will migrate the database to a cloud-based infrastructure and implement data encryption to comply with security protocols.”*
2. *“The application will undergo regression testing to identify potential issues caused by recent code changes.”*
3. *“The mobile version will support push notifications and synchronize in real time with the desktop app.”*



Production

CASE STUDY: ANALYSE IT PROJECT BRIEFS

Work in pairs or small groups to analyze IT project briefs and discuss whether the briefing styles are suitable for each context:

**Note: Use analysis questions as your guidelines.*

Case Study 1: Setting Up Cloud Storage

Two IT managers are briefing the software development team about the transition to new cloud storage.

Team Manager A	Team Manager B
<i>"We're migrating all project directories to our new Azure cloud infrastructure. Please begin transitioning your team's source code repositories and documents to OneDrive using authenticated single sign-on. Remember to enable multi-factor authentication and tag all shared folders according to our standard protocol."</i>	<i>"From now on, please save your work in an online folder instead of your own computer. It's safer and means you can work from anywhere."</i>

Analysis Questions:

- Which briefing would a technical team prefer? Why?
- When is it important to use precise technical terms?
- What could go wrong with only a simple explanation in this context?

Case Study 2: Explaining the Firewall Upgrade

Three IT managers are presenting to a team with IT, HR, and sales representatives about the security change.

Team Manager A	<i>"Our new stateful inspection firewall is configured to monitor all incoming and outgoing network packets. Please report any blocked connections with detailed info on your port and protocol."</i>
Team Manager B	<i>"We upgraded our security guard for the internet. If you see any strange warnings, please tell us."</i>
Team Manager C	<i>"We recently upgraded our perimeter firewall to include stateful inspection, which means it now checks every signal in and out for signs of attack. In simple terms, the firewall is like a guard at the company gate, helping keep out hackers and unsafe software. If you ever get a warning about blocked access, let us know—it's usually the firewall doing its job to keep everyone safe."</i>

Analysis Questions:

- Which manager's brief is the most effective in this context?
- Who benefits from technical detail? Who benefits from the easier explanation?
- Is anything missing from one style alone?

Case Study 3: Reporting a Bug

The customer service team regularly uses a new software platform. Some staff have noticed problems, but they're unsure how to report these to IT. Two IT managers need to explain the procedure for reporting bugs.

Team Manager A	Team Manager B
<i>"If you encounter any system anomalies or error messages, please log the incident in the bug tracking system, specifying the steps to reproduce the issue and attaching relevant logs or screenshots."</i>	<i>"If something goes wrong with your program—for example, if you see a strange message or it doesn't work as expected—please send us an email describing exactly what happened. If you can, include a picture or tell us what you were doing before the problem."</i>

Analysis Questions:

- Which briefing is easier to understand for the team in this situation? Why?
- What problems might happen if you only use the technical briefing?
- Is there any information missing from the simpler briefing? How could it be improved?

Discussion:

1. In what type of situation is it better to use technical terms? When should you use simple language? Give examples.
2. In your opinion, what is the best way to explain this IT information to a non-technical team?
3. When you are listening to a technical explanation, what can you do if you don't understand? What useful questions can you ask?
4. What strategies can you use in the future to communicate technical ideas more clearly to people with different backgrounds?